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National Survey of Children's Health

Data File Enhancement Technical Document

National Survey of Children's Health Historical File Enhancements (2016 to 2021)

In 2023, the Maternal and Child Health Bureau (MCHB) initiated an effort to bring a number of file enhancements to past releases of the National Survey of Children's Health. Major improvements include more reliable and granular reporting by race and ethnicity, additional reporting relevant to BMI, and integrating data corrections on breastfeeding, solid foods and formula.

- Race and Ethnicity
    - We identified a pattern of unreliable race reporting on the web instrument after respondents attempted to skip this question. In these cases, reported values were replaced with imputed values.
    - We modified weighting dimensions to better align race reporting between the NSCH and the American Community Survey (ACS), which is used to create population controls by race.
    - The 'Some other race' response option was removed from the NSCH after 2018. For historical consistency, responses of 'Some other race' to the 2016, 2017 and 2018 NSCH were imputed to one of the race response options available after 2018.
    - We added race 'alone or in combination' flags for American Indian/Alaska Native (SC_AIAN), Asian (SC_ASIAN) and Native Hawaiian or Other Pacific Islander (SC_NHPI).
- Height, Weight and BMICLASS
    - We added variables on the child's reported height (HEIGHT) and weight (WEIGHT).
    - We extended the reported ages for BMI (BMICLASS) to 6 to 17 years old; HEIGHT and WEIGHT are also available for children 6 to 17 years old.
- Breastfeeding corrections
    - In 2022, MCHB identified a discrepancy in reported values for breastfeeding (BREASTFEDEND_MO_S), first fed formula (FRSTFORMULA_MO_S) and first fed solids (FRSTSOLIDS_MO_S). A supplemental file with corrected values is available on the respective data release pages (NSCH Data Release (census.gov)). The enhanced files include the corrected values natively.
- Children with Special Health Care Needs (CSHCN)
    - In 2021, weighting procedures were modified to remove a CSHCN dimension in the final stage of weighting estimation due to oversampling of households with a higher likelihood of having younger children. For historical comparability, this change is reflected in all survey years from 2016 forward in this file enhancement.

Modifications to the data by race and ethnicity are sufficiently substantial that we do not recommend comparing estimates using original data released from 2016 to 2021 against estimates using data released in or after October 2023. Similarly, the weighting modification for CSHCN is sufficiently substantial that we do not recommend comparing estimates using original data from 2016 to 2020 to those released in or after October 2023. The files released prior to October 2023 are no longer available for download and should be replaced by the enhanced files for future analyses.

Naming convention: The naming conventions for NSCH Data files prior to enhancement has been nsch_[yyyy]_[instrument], e.g., nsch_2021_topical. Enhanced files are indicated will use the following convention: nsch_[yyyy]e_[instrument], e.g., nsch_2021e_topical.